

Κέρκωψ ὁ Ὀρφικός

Cercops the Orphic on Pythagorean Testimony

eul_aid: bay

Period: Ἀρχαϊκή [Archaic](#)
Dialect: Ἑπική [Epic](#) (Homeric)
Domain: Φιλοσοφία [Philosophy](#)
Format: Συναγωγή [Collection](#)
Affiliation: [Pythagorean](#)

Cercops the Orphic was a Greek writer and philosopher believed to have lived in the sixth century BCE. Ancient sources identify him as a Pythagorean, placing him within the influential philosophical and religious communities of southern Italy, though his specific life details are not recorded.

He is traditionally credited as the author of a major Orphic poem, the **Descent to Hades**, which narrates the mythical singer Orpheus's journey to the underworld. The poem itself is lost, surviving only through later references. The attribution of this sacred text to Cercops, rather than to the legendary Orpheus, is a notable feature of the ancient testimony.

Cercops's significance lies in his role as a historical figure within the Orphic tradition. This tradition consisted of poems on the soul, purification, and the afterlife that were attributed to Orpheus but were actually composed by various authors. According to modern scholars, linking the **Descent to Hades** to a known Pythagorean like Cercops highlights the close connection between Orphic religious texts and Pythagorean philosophical interests during the archaic period. His example illustrates how revelatory literature was produced and ascribed to a foundational mythical figure within specific ancient communities.

Works (1)

- [Μαρτυρία](#) · [Testimony](#) · 1 passages

Other Pythagorean Authors

- Ἀπολλόδωρος ὁ Κυζικηνός · [Apollodorus of Cyzicus](#) · 1 work
- Ἀπολλώνιος ὁ Τυανεύς · [Apollonius of Tyana](#) · 3 works
- Ἀπολλώνιος ὁ Τυανεύς · [Apollonius of Tyana II](#) · 1 work
- Ἀρχύτας ὁ Ταραντῖνος · [Archytas of Tarentum](#) · 2 works
- Ἀρέσας ὁ Λευκανός · [Aresas of Lucania](#) · 1 work
- Ἀθάμας ὁ Ποσειδωνιάτης · [Athamas of Posidonia](#) · 1 work
- Βροντῖνος ὁ Μεταποντῖνος · [Brontinus of Metapontum](#) · 2 works
- Κλεινίας ὁ Ταραντῖνος · [Clinias of Tarentum](#) · 2 works
- Δάμων καὶ Φιντίας · [Damon and Phintias](#) · 1 work
- Ἐχεκράτης ὁ Φλιάσιος · [Echecrates of Phlius](#) · 1 work

- Ἐκφάντος ὁ Πυθαγόρειος · Ecphantus the Pythagorean · 2 works
- Εὐρυφάμος · Euryphamus the Philosopher · 1 work